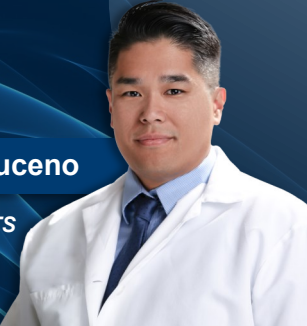




Generalized Anxiety Disorder (GAD) for Adults

What is GAD?

Generalized anxiety disorder (GAD) is excessive worry and tension about everyday events, on most days, for at least six months, to the extent that there is distress or difficulty in performing day-to-day tasks.¹ It is a very common complaint seen on our virtual platforms, where we can make a large impact on that patient's care.

GAD Assessments

History is the primary tool to assess individuals with anxiety. By using the GAD-7 calculator, we can assess frequency, character, and severity of symptoms. It can also be used periodically to monitor symptoms and judge response to treatment.³

The GAD-7 can be found under **Questionnaires** in HealthConnect.

Questionnaires

GAD

+ Add

Recent

GENERALIZED ANXIETY DISORDER 7 - ITEM (GAD - 7) SCALE [101574]

GENERALIZED ANXIETY DISORDER 7 - ITEM (GAD - 7) SCALE

Over the last 2 weeks, how often have you been bothered by the following problems?

1. Feeling nervous, anxious, or on edge

2. Not being able to stop or control worrying

3. Worrying too much about different things

4. Trouble relaxing

5. Being so restless that it's hard to sit still

6. Becoming easily annoyed or irritable

7. Feeling afraid as if something awful might happen

Total Score: Add the score for each column

If you checked off any problems, how difficult have these made it for you to do your work, take care of things at home, or get along with other people?

Answer

Answer

0 = Not at all sure

1 = Several days

2 = Over half the days

3 = Nearly every day

GAD Management

Patients with mild symptoms may initially opt to avoid treatment. If symptoms worsen or impact daily function, treatment is recommended.

Non-Pharmacologic Therapy

Include education to the patient on:

- Anxiety
- [CALM App](#)
- [myStrength App](#)
- Exercise
- Cognitive behavioral therapy²
- Kaiser Permanente educational programs

Pharmacologic Therapy

For patients with moderate to severe anxiety, order SRX ANXIETY.

Alternative Selection

Alternative Required

You selected:

SMARTRX - ELDERCARE, ANXIETY, NO BENZOS,: Starting 8/19/2024, Fill Later

Details

* Avoid the use of benzodiazepines in the elderly

* Benzodiazepines can increase the risk of cognitive impairment, falls, hip fractures, and death in the elderly

* Benzodiazepines are considered "high risk medication in the elderly" and are on the American Geriatric Society Beers Criteria list

* Safer treatments for anxiety disorders in the elderly include serotonin reuptake inhibitors and psychotherapy

* BusPIRone is non-habit forming and less likely to cause side effects. It also has a lower potential for interaction with other medications

* Reassess continued need for medication

References

HEDIS 2023 - Use of High-Risk Medications in Older Adults (DAE)

Alternatives

Alternative	Details
☐ sertraline 25 mg tab (ZOLOFT), 1 daily, #100	25 mg, Oral, DAILY
☐ FLUoxetine 10 mg cap (PROzac), 1 daily, #100	10 mg, Oral, DAILY
☐ DULoxetine 20 mg cap (CYMBALTA), (avoid if CrCl <30 mL/min), 1 dai...	20 mg, Oral, DAILY
☐ busPIRone 5 mg tab (BUSPAR), 1.5 daily, #150	7.5 mg, Oral, DAILY
☐ escitalopram 5 mg tab (LEXAPRO), max 10 mg/day, 1 daily, #100	5 mg, Oral, DAILY
☐ citalopram 10 mg tab (CeleXA), max 20 mg/day, 1 daily, #100	10 mg, Oral, DAILY

Accept Alternative

Remove Order

Recommend that the patient follow up in a month with a PCP. If the provider feels it is appropriate, they can also refer the patient to Behavioral Medicine.

For 24/7 crisis intervention and urgent mental health advice, please call [1-800-900-3277](tel:1-800-900-3277).

GAD Prognosis

One study found that 25% of adults with GAD will be in full remission after 2 years, and 38% remission after 5 years.¹

GAD for Pediatric Patients

When treating pediatric patients with GAD, non-pharmacologic therapies are preferred. If these treatments have been ineffective, referral to pediatric psychiatrist may be warranted to consider pharmacotherapies.

Introducing the GPC Mailbag!

At GPC Clinical Corner, we strive to provide tips on the best clinical practices, navigating patient encounters, and updated information on treatment options.

This year, we'd like to expand our scope to include your suggestions. We're proud to announce the GPC Mailbag, where you can request topics for discussion, or even specific questions, that you'd like to see in a future newsletter. You can reach us at GPCMailbag@kp.org. We look forward to hearing from you!

References

Gale, C. K. & Millichamp, J. (2011). Generalized Anxiety Disorder. *BMJ Clinical Evidence*. <https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/22030083/>

Kaiser Permanente Clinical Library. (2022). Benzodiazepines & non-benzodiazepine sedative-hypnotics/Z drugs practice recommendations (for adults 18 and over). Kaiser Permanente. https://cl.kp.org/natl/cmi/interregional/controlled_substances/sedative-hypnotics.html?q=Mental%20Health%20%26%20Social&context=clinical-decision-support

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CTCARE TRANSFORMATION

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